people around him. He still cares, of course, and in a purely playing sense I feel sympathetic towards him, because he has been here, there and everywhere in the batting order. He is cricket's answer to a Post-it note, a utility player who can be stuck anywhere on the scorecard. He doesn't make a fuss.

It has been a tough gig. He came in, under Moores, as a batsman who could bowl a bit of spin. When Graeme Swann retired, and Monty Panesar waned, he was thrown into the breach. He worked incredibly hard, with Mushtaq Ahmed's help, to become a very, very good off-spinner. They shared a cultural link, a respect for seniority that has, in turn, been passed on to Adil Rashid. Someday, someone is going to make a buddy movie called *Mo'n'Rash* . Their families lived about fifteen miles apart in northern Pakistan, and they played against each other in their early teens. As they have grown older, they have derived stability and guidance from their religion. They are inseparable.

Rash has taken time to bed in at the highest level, but as a leg-spinner he is an integral member of England's white-ball team. In broader terms, Mo suggests that English cricket's failure to make the most of the talent pool containing second and third generation Asian immigrants is a complicated issue that will work itself out, with time. Together they represent powerful proof that international sport can be a multicultural, unifying force.

It also has a certain impatience, reflected in the attitude of some of those on the fringes. I was pulled up short at the end of that 2016 tour of South Africa when a radio reporter asked me whether, having won two Ashes series, and won in India and South Africa, I was considering stepping down. 'You've achieved everything as a captain,' he said. 'Are you going to stop?'

On the one hand, that sort of question to a professional sportsman is abrupt to the point of being offensive. On the other, I knew what he was getting at. He wasn't quite reading my mind, but I was nibbling at the fringes of the issue with increasing interest. Losing the last four Tests in India in the run-up to Christmas that year took me to a tipping point.

To be fair to everyone concerned, I had to signal my intention to continue as captain through the following winter's Ashes series in Australia. I ignored the background noise of pundits like Geoffrey Boycott calling for me to stand down and concentrated on the inner voice that occasionally speaks sense. I'd had a record run of fifty-nine Tests in charge. The time was right to return to the ranks. Rooty was ready to lead. We both had the